

The 28-Day CES Compliance Audit

Find the CES Gaps in Your REC Before ESV Does

A practical self-audit workbook for Victorian Registered Electrical Contractors

• 5-point pre-audit checklist • Penalty exposure calculator • Common CES gaps • ESV response playbook

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Why This Matters

If you issue Certificates of Electrical Safety (CES) in Victoria, this workbook is the most important 20 minutes you will spend on compliance this year.

In 2026, Energy Safe Victoria has increased audit activity across the electrical contracting sector — with a specific focus on solar and battery installations. A routine compliance audit can uncover multiple CES failures, and the combined penalty exposure for even a small number of late or missing certificates can reach **\$15,000–\$30,000** in a single inspection.

This workbook walks you through a 5-point self-audit that mirrors the areas ESV checks in a first-stage compliance review. Run it against your current CES record and you will see exactly where your gaps are — before ESV does.

The 5-Point CES Self-Audit

Print this section and run through each point against your current CES record.

1	Lodgement Timeline Check	Pull your last 10 CES. For each one, note the date the work was completed and the date the CES was lodged. Any gap over 28 days is a compliance breach. Any gap over 28 days where you cannot produce the CES record is an audit risk.
2	Certificate Completeness	Check that each CES includes: contractor name and REC number, installation address, description of work, date of completion, and signature. Missing fields = invalid CES in ESV's view.
3	Equipment Documentation	For solar/battery installations: does the CES reference panel brand, model, quantity, inverter details, and system capacity? AS/NZS 5033 compliance evidence should accompany the certificate.
4	DNSP Notification	For grid-connected solar: was the DNSP separately notified? The CES alone does not satisfy network notification requirements. Check distributor rules for your area (CitiPower, Powercor, AusNet, United Energy, Jemena).
5	Record Keeping	Do you have a backup copy of every CES lodged? ESV recommends keeping records for 7 years. If your ESV Connect account were inaccessible tomorrow, could you reconstruct your compliance history?

Penalty Exposure Calculator

Be honest — estimate conservatively. Total your exposure across each row.

Violation	Per Late	Per Audit	Count	Your Risk
1-7 days late	Nil	Nil — grace applies	___	—
8-28 days late	Nil (within deadline)	Potential escalation	___	—
29+ days late	\$150–\$300	\$300–\$600	___	\$___
CES never lodged	\$500–\$1,500	\$2,000–\$5,000	___	\$___
Incomplete CES	N/A	\$500–\$2,000	___	\$___
Missing DNSP notice	Possible recall	\$1,000–\$3,000	___	\$___

Note: The "Per Audit" column applies ESV's escalation multiplier — penalties are typically 2-3x higher when discovered during a formal audit vs proactive lodgement.

3 Common CES Gaps (and How to Fix Them)

Gap 1: Solar & Battery Installations

The #1 CES compliance gap in 2026. Solar and battery installations involve both electrical work (requiring a CES) and STC creation (requiring CEC documentation). Many installers confuse the two processes or assume the CEC paperwork satisfies the CES requirement. **It does not.** The CES is a separate legal obligation under the Electricity Safety Act 1998.

Fix: Create a job template in your system that auto-generates a CES checklist for every solar/battery job, completed before the install team leaves site.

Gap 2: Switchboard Upgrades

Switchboard upgrades are high-risk for CES gaps because they are often "add-on" work — a customer asks for a switchboard replacement during a solar or EV install, and the electrician treats it as an extension of the existing job rather than a separate notifiable installation. The CES requirement applies to the switchboard work independently.

Fix: Always issue a separate CES for switchboard upgrade work, even when it is part of a larger job scope.

Gap 3: Emergency Call-Outs

Emergency call-outs — after-hours faults, safety hazards, temporary repairs — are the most commonly overlooked CES triggers. An electrician attends a residential after-hours fault, replaces a damaged switchboard component, and leaves without issuing a CES because it was "just a quick fix." Under Victorian regulations, if the work involved alteration to fixed wiring, a CES is required.

Fix: Train every technician that any work involving fixed wiring — even emergency repairs — requires a CES. Add a CES reminder to your emergency call-out workflow.

Lodgement Workflow: The 48-Hour Rule

The regulation says 28 days. The best-practice target for avoiding audit flags: **48 hours**.
ESV cross-references job completion dates against CES lodgement dates. A pattern of CES lodged at 25-28 days — even within the legal window — flags your REC for "late lodgement clustering" and increases audit probability. The 48-hour rule eliminates this risk entirely.

1	Job Complete	Technician marks job as complete on-site via mobile app.
2	Data Entry	Lodge CES details: address, REC number, work description, equipment.
3	Review	Technician reviews CES for completeness. Attach compliance photos. Sign.
4	ESV Connect	Admin logs into ESV Connect, enters CES data, submits. Save receipt.
5	DNSP Notify	For solar: notify distributor (CitiPower, Powercor, AusNet, etc.).
6	Archive	Store CES confirmation PDF. Maintain records 7 years. Backup quarterly.

The ESV Response Playbook

If you receive a compliance notice from ESV, follow these steps.

Step 1: Read the Notice Carefully

ESV compliance notices specify the alleged breach, the period under review, and documents required. Response window is typically 14-28 days. Do not respond until you have gathered all the requested information — a rushed partial response triggers escalation.

Step 2: Conduct Your Own Audit First

Before submitting anything to ESV, run the 5-point self-audit from this workbook against the period under review. Identify every gap, not just the ones ESV asked about. They may expand the scope if they find issues beyond the original notice.

Step 3: Prepare a Remediation Plan

For each gap, document: what went wrong, when it was fixed, and the system change that prevents recurrence. ESV responds favourably to RECs who demonstrate proactive remediation.

Step 4: Get Professional Support

If penalty exposure exceeds \$5,000 or involves potential licence conditions, engage a compliance lawyer. MEA and NECA both offer compliance support to members.

Step 5: Submit a Complete Response

Include: the completed notice, your self-audit results, your remediation plan, and evidence of system changes. Submit before the deadline — extensions are rarely granted.

Resources

- Energy Safe Victoria — esv.vic.gov.au
- ESV Connect portal — e-services.esv.vic.gov.au
- Master Electricians Australia — masterelectricians.com.au
- NECA Victoria — neca.asn.au/vic
- TradieAutomate CES Guide — tradieautomate.com/blog/certificate-electrical-safety-ces-victoria-guide-2026/

Disclaimer

This e-book is a practical compliance guide, not legal advice. Regulatory requirements and penalty amounts change over time. Always verify current requirements directly with Energy Safe Victoria or your legal advisor before taking compliance action. Current as of October 2026.